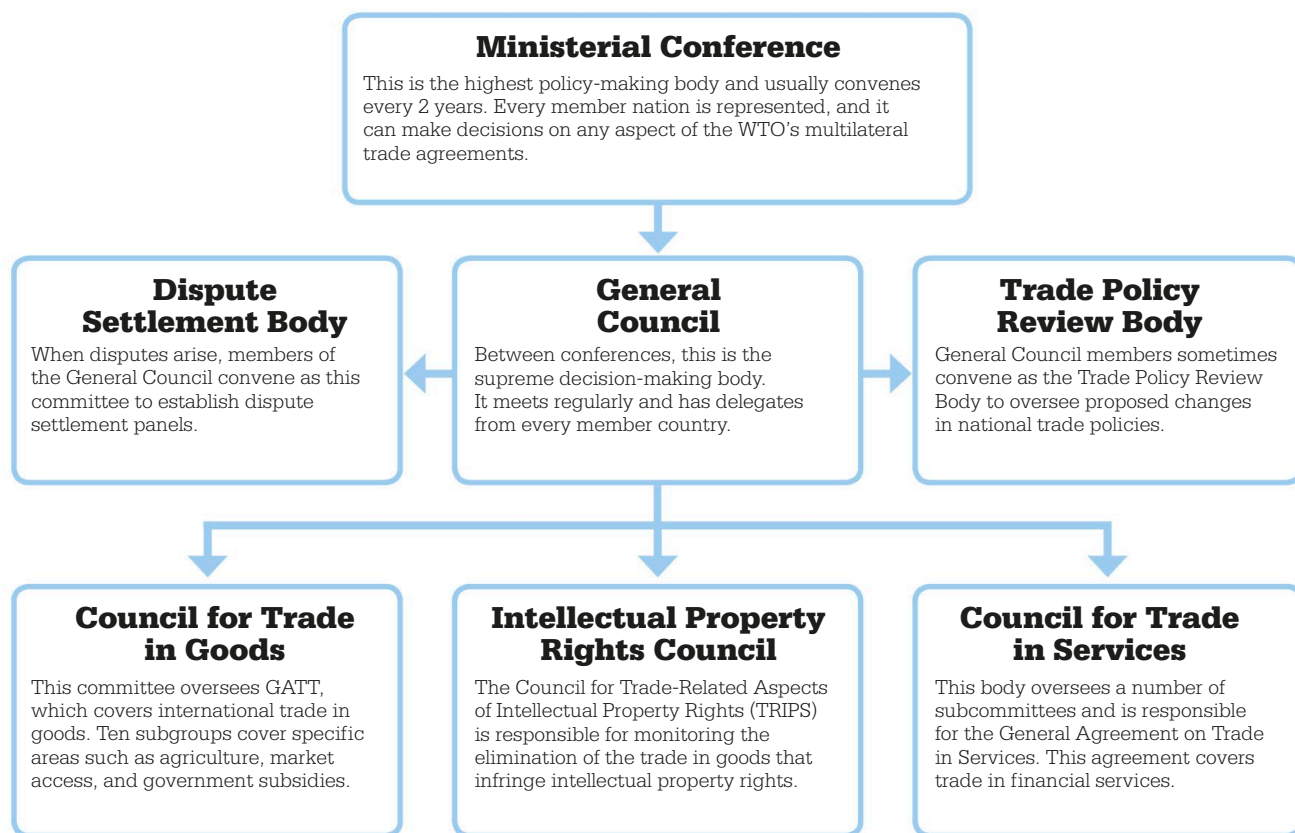


The structure of the World Trade Organization



stable trading conditions that will encourage investment and job creation. This, it is hoped, will boost developing nations, lifting their people from poverty and allowing them to compete equally with the developed world.

The WTO coordinates its efforts with the IMF and World Bank and has used trade sanctions against countries deemed to have abused its rules. Generally every 2 years, a ministerial conference convenes to make big decisions. Committees overseeing trade in goods and services, and the contentious issue of intellectual property rights, meet more regularly, and subcommittees negotiate the minutiae of trade

policy. The Appellate Body, an independent committee of seven trade law experts, was established in 1995. It considers reports from dispute settlement panels, which it has the power to overturn.

Varied criticisms

The WTO is ponderous and slow to react because it has to consider a very large number of conflicting interests. Critics accuse it of being in thrall to the interests of its most powerful members. They also question the transparency of the WTO's decisions and argue that it discriminates against developing nations. One consistent criticism is that in seeking to

defend intellectual property rights (especially proprietary rights of a business over any product it has created), the WTO has denied the potential benefits of medicines, in particular, to countries unable to afford them. For example, companies that invested in developing "patented" original HIV medicines forced cheaper but equally effective generic medicines out of many markets in the developing world. In such cases, profits and shareholders' dividends seem to have taken preference over patients.

Further criticisms have been leveled against trade blocs that have successfully used their economic muscle to impose tariffs that are